MANAGING MELTDOWNS

In the heat of the meltdown:

Keep them safe

Calm yourself

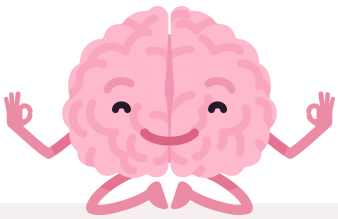
Just be there

Move any sharp/dangerous items or furniture away from them

Move your child to a space that is safer (such as a carpeted area or the couch)

Be a calm presence in the same room as them, or take a break to calm yourself down and then come back

In a quiet voice:
“This is feeling really hard right now”
“I’m here to help you when you’re ready”



Just being calm in their presence helps them "catch your calm"

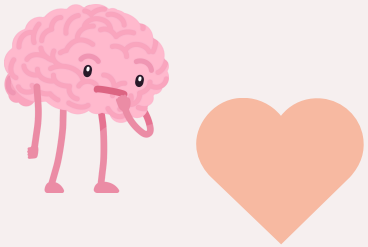
ADAPTED FROM THE MOM POWER VIRTUAL GROUP CURRICULUM (MUZIK & ROSENBLUM ET AL., UNPUBLISHED MANUAL, 2021)

MANAGING MELTDOWNS

AS THE MELTDOWN STARTS TO RESOLVE:

Help them put words to their feelings

- "I wonder if you felt..."



Validate their feelings (be empathetic)

- "I can understand why you felt that way"
- "It makes sense that..."

Set limits around behavior as needed

- Use language about safety to explain why certain behaviors aren't ok
- Help your child come up with other safe ways to express their feelings
- Asking them "what would you do instead?" can sometimes feel like a quiz/judgment and can lead to kids shutting down
- Instead, try "let's think of other ideas together. What about taking a deep breath or stomping your foot?"

All feelings are ok, and Behaviors have limits.

"It's ok to feel mad, but it's not safe to throw sticks because they can hurt people. **Let's think of safe things you can do when you're mad."**

"I can see that you're feeling mad about leaving the park -- **I understand**, it's a lot of fun to play and you don't want to go home and nap!"